

The Principle of Personality in Philosophy

Lectures at the University of Helsingfors, Spring 1911

Harald Høffding

Translated from the Danish by [HH]

Personlighedsprincippet i Filosofien, trans. Mogens Blegvad, ed. Carl
Henrik Koch.

Scientia Danica, Series H, Humanistica, 8, vol. 6.
Copenhagen: Det Kgl. Danske Videnskabernes Selskab, 2013

Contents

I. Personality as the Presupposition of Science	2
II. Personality as an Object of Science	7
III. The Principle of Personality in Psychology	12
IV. The Principle of Personality in Ethics	17
V. Can the Principle of Personality Be Proved and Carried Through?	22
VI. The Principle of Personality and the View of Life	26

I. Personality as the Presupposition of Science

By the principle of personality I understand the thought that the human being, at every point and in every respect, is to be treated—by others and by himself—as an end, never merely as a means. Even where the human being serves—serves other human beings, serves society, serves a cause, an idea—he is at the same time to be an end himself, in that this serving ought to lead to the development and ennoblement of his own being, of his own individual distinctiveness. It is an ideal that is set up in this principle, which was first formulated with full clarity and definiteness by Immanuel Kant (1785). In the Nordic countries it was asserted with great emphasis by Erik Gustaf Geijer in Sweden (1842), from whom the term “the principle of personality” derives. Whereas Kant set up this principle in opposition partly to the principle of authority, partly to an external morality of utility and happiness, Geijer set it up against the romantically conservative “historical school,” which laid weight solely on institutions and traditions as they happened to have developed, and he found more and more that this principle contained everything for which he had worked—in literature, in politics, and in religion. In Denmark the principle is expressed, particularly in the religious domain, at roughly the same time (1846) by F.C. Sibbern and Søren Kierkegaard. — If we were to follow the history of the principle further back in time, we would come on the one hand to Christianity and the weight it laid on the individual soul, on the other to the Socratic insistence on the importance of self-knowledge and self-examination.

The justification of the principle is very different among its various representatives. I shall return to this in connection with the inquiry into whether the principle admits of any binding proof at all. Here I will attempt to set forth all that it contains. It is first and foremost set up as an ethical and religious principle; but I believe that it also contains points of view of great importance for a correct conception of the relation of science to life. It has intellectual, not merely ethical and religious, significance, and I shall examine it from all these three sides. What Geijer said of his age—that it “is an age that suffers from its own thoughts,” in that “the inner world [...] gives way in its very foundations, in its faith, its conviction, its knowledge,” and that “the fundamental and mother-thought that here strives to come forth and make its way, and under

whose birth-pangs the world trembles”¹ is precisely the principle of personality—this surely holds true to this very day. The crisis is not over; it has merely assumed somewhat different forms than in Geijer’s time. Geijer’s words aptly express that here is a thought which has involuntarily worked its way forward, but which can come into its full right only by becoming an object of clear consciousness.

When we now begin with the intellectual significance of the principle of personality, we meet the objection that in science it is precisely a matter of disregarding our personality—its striving, its pleasure and pain, its hope and its fear. Ought we not precisely to divest ourselves of our personality if we would be researchers, if we would find the great laws of existence that hold for each and all? In science we are led into a common world. But every personality has its own little world, which is different from everyone else’s, and which, like the dream-world, stands in opposition to the waking reality common to all. Can the personality here demand more than to be allowed to live in its world of dreams, so long as science does not draw this world under the strict law of its research?

I enter for a moment into this analogy between dream and reality on the one hand, personality and science on the other. Psychology shows that the same laws hold for consciousness in dreams and in the waking state. In both there is revealed a need for, and a capacity for, comprehending and ordering all experiences, all sensations, all feelings, and all thoughts. In dreams this happens in a more abrupt and apparently irregular manner—now ingeniously, now stupidly. In the waking state it happens more according to definite theoretical and practical points of view (although here too both stupidity and ingenuity can occur). Analogous is the relation between personality and science. It is a kindred need and a kindred capacity that is at work in both. We speak of personality only where there appears a striving for coherence in the life of the soul, a striving to gather all psychic elements and to direct them in definite directions. Continuity and concentration are the special marks of personality. Science is merely a definite, specially developed form of this distinctiveness. In so far as there exists an opposition between personality and science, it must be established that it lies within the personality—that it concerns the relation between the personality as a whole and

¹E.G. Geijer, *Samlade skrifter*, sec. I, vol. 6, Stockholm: P.A. Norstedt & Söner, 1853, p. 287.

one of its special expressions of life.

It is precisely one of the chief tasks of philosophy to investigate how and why scientific consciousness develops as a special form of personal life. Philosophical reflection seeks to answer the question of how the nature of the human mind expresses itself both in the work that leads to a great, common world-picture, and in the work that perhaps acquires significance merely by bringing harmony and order into the individual's little world. This little world need not be a dream-world; here the analogy mentioned above cannot be applied without further ado—at any rate there is here a special problem to which we shall later return.

It is the critical philosophy that has, with the greatest energy, maintained that the work of thought in science cannot be completed, and cannot be understood in its full significance, without taking into account the nature and conditions of conscious beings. Every objective truth has a subjective foundation, even though one cannot infer this truth from the merely subjective foundation.

The historical origin of science is to be found wherever the human being has had the experience that he can attain his ends only along quite definite paths. He would rather attain them immediately. Only when compelled by experience does he take roundabout ways. And he then stands before a connection to which he must bow. Here occurs his first encounter with the necessity that science discloses at one point after another. Science demands resignation. The human being here thinks in order to live. Thought, and thereby the work of personality, is here merely a means. But it is a means that can itself become an end by becoming an object of immediate interest. It becomes an independent task to come to know the great connection within which personal life is lived, to find an order of things more comprehensive than the individual's own little world. And then the human being can live in order to think. He grows with the more comprehensive ends he thus sets himself. The personality becomes richer the larger a circle of experiences it embraces, provided only that it can gather them into a harmonious unity, or at least divine and seek such a unity. It is easy enough to concentrate when there is only a poor and limited content to comprehend, when no great oppositions, no wealth of experiences, lay claim to the psychic energy. The world of the personality must be expanded for this energy rightly to show itself.

Science and its history become intelligible only when there exists an inner connection between scientific work and the whole life and activity of the personality. Scientific work presupposes an energy and an enthusiasm, an *amor intellectualis*, which is not possible without an inner connection between science and personality. And such a connection presupposes, in turn, that it is no alien power to which the personality bows when, through research, it is led to recognize a great connection that points far beyond its own little world. The longing to find truth along the path that science indicates is merely a special form of the longing for agreement with oneself amid all manifold and changing experiences—the longing in which the personality’s own being consists. And even where the personality keenly senses the opposition between its own little world and the unsurveyable world—reaching beyond all human action and ends—for which science opens the eyes, it belongs precisely to the nobility of the personality, as well as to its duty, to find by its own power, by the exertion of its own thought’s energy, the great laws that condition its existence and its worth. The personality is purified by seeing its existence conditioned and limited by the great connection of things.

Scientific work does not lay claim in equal degree to all sides of the personality. In his research the human being must proceed from definite points of view, follow definite paths, develop his life of thought according to certain definite methods, which, to be sure, are special forms of personal life in general, but which in the course of mankind’s long labor of thought have proved their indispensability. Science works with certain fundamental concepts or fundamental predicates, which from of old are called categories, and which together constitute an armament that adapts itself both to the personality and to the resistance that the work of thought is to overcome.² At times one has called the personality, in so far as it appears in this armament, “the pure I,” in opposition to “the empirical I,” which shows us the personality in its whole individual reality, with all its experiences, representations, wishes, and drives. The pure I is the I of the solitude of thought, of the study and the laboratory, the I that works strictly with the “categories.” But it is merely a particular formation—necessitated by the

²Cf. H. Høffding, *Den menneskelige Tanke, dens Former og dens Opgaver* [The Human Mind: Its Forms and Its Tasks], Copenhagen and Kristiania: Gyldendalske Boghandel, Nordisk Forlag, 1910, ch. 3: “Tankens Former (Kategorier)” [The Forms of Thought (Categories)], pp. 135–245.

division of labor—of the same I that manifests itself in representations, wishes, and drives. There is no absolute difference between them, and their mutual relation can appear in countless nuances in different individuals. There are researchers who are transformed into wholly other people when they step out of the solitude of thought into ordinary life. But this is an imperfection that points to an unresolved disharmony in personal life itself.

On this point stands the dispute of our days between criticism and pragmatism. The first is (already in its founder Immanuel Kant) inclined to regard “the pure I,” the sum of the forms of investigating thought (the categories), as given once and for all, independent of all experience and history (including science’s own history). The latter is (both in the form Ernst Mach and in the form William James have given it) inclined to regard the forms and presuppositions necessary for scientific work as merely conditioned by external tasks and practical interests, without their standing in any inner connection with human nature itself. In my view this contradiction falls away when one more closely examines the nature and development of the individual forms of thought. In my book *The Human Mind* I have worked in this direction and have thereby been strengthened in the conviction that the human being in science neither stands merely as a means for the application of certain pure forms nor for the solution of externally given tasks.

When science thus, in its origin, points back to the human personality and appears as a special form of the work that every personality has to perform in order to assert and develop itself, its personal character becomes visible from another and more individual side at the conclusion of scientific work. An absolute conclusion, a conclusion once and for all, is not possible, because life and experience continually go further. But each individual researcher shall and must stop at a definite point, where inner and outer causes prevent him from going further. And then he must of course seek an overview, a summation, a rounding-off. He must also attempt a glimpse into the unexplored, if not unexplorable, regions, just as one casts light into the darkness with an electric searchlight. Here it is not merely “the pure I” that works; the other sides of the personality must more or less take part. One sees this, for example, in the natural scientist’s attempt to set his results in relation to his whole view of the world. And one

sees it when the historical researcher passes from critical scrutiny of the sources to the writing of history; this requires a rounding-off in which the researcher's personality asserts itself more than during the critical work. One sees it still more in philosophy, when it passes from criticism to system, from analysis to synthesis.

Philosophical systems ought never to have wished to be more than an individual rounding-off. A rounding-off can be justified even though a conclusion is impossible. Goethe characterized his research with the principle: "Nie geschlossen, oft gerundet!" [Never closed, often rounded!] And in the rounding-off the individual character ought to be expressly acknowledged. The truly significant systems lose nothing thereby, but acquire through it a special interest. Even the system that is often regarded as the most objective and impersonal of all—Spinoza's—proves on closer examination to be permeated by its founder's personality; it constitutes the band that unites the many lines of thought into a unity. Through whole trains of thought one feels the master's undaunted consistency, his great resignation, and his heartfelt absorption in the work of thought, which for him was a religion. It is not least this that makes many return again and again, and ever with new profit, to this artwork of thought.

The interest that the history of philosophy presents rests for a large part on this personal element. The history of philosophy can be regarded as a great dialogue, whose individual lines stem from researcher-personalities, each of whom, on the basis of the science and culture of his age, has developed a type of thought, a more or less essential view of existence. For philosophy, its history has, precisely because of the principle of personality, greater significance than for other sciences. It stands, in this as in other respects, between science and art. And for many it is precisely herein that its great power of attraction lies.

II. Personality as an Object of Science

For a correct conception of science one must see in it a fruit of personal work. Thereby both the fear of its results and pride over them are excluded.

But the personality is not merely the subject of science. It is at the same time itself one of the objects of science. Science turns toward it as toward a given subject-matter,

whose nature and origin are to be understood and explained. The personal factor that co-operates in all science can and ought itself to be made an object of science. The world is understood through the human being (*ex analogia hominis*); knowledge of the world is conditioned by the capacities and forms of human thought. But the human being is himself a part of the world, which can be understood only in its connection with the rest of the world. The human being is thus understood through the world (*ex analogia universi*).

As Pascal has said: "In space the universe comprehends (*comprend*) me and engulfs me as a point; but in thought I comprehend (*comprends*) the universe."

The two modes of consideration do not conflict with one another. They are two points of view, both of which must be adopted, and which stand in inner reciprocal action. Human thought, which works to solve the riddles of existence, has itself developed within existence. The presuppositions that condition and limit our conception of the world have themselves their history. It is not least the necessity of this double point of view that makes an absolute conclusion of knowledge impossible. We cannot apply both points of view at once. We cannot at one and the same time stand on our head and on our feet; but we can (perhaps) first do the one and then the other.

Against making the personality an object of science, however, one of the finest thinkers in present-day Germany, Heinrich Rickert, has raised an interesting objection in his work *Die Grenzen der naturwissenschaftlichen Begriffsbildung* (1901–02). Rickert defends a sharp opposition between natural science and history (the science of mind); the first concerns the universal and general, that which constantly repeats itself—the latter has for its object something that happens only once (*das Einmalige*), individual events and individual figures. The purely natural-scientific method aims at finding general concepts and laws under which the individual phenomena can be subsumed as examples. The historical sciences, by contrast, stop at individual totalities. The natural-scientific concepts are general concepts, the historical concepts are individual concepts.³

³"Von den Individuen gibt es keine Naturwissenschaft, weil sich nichts Besonderes mehr ihnen unterordnen lässt, in Vergleich zu dem sie noch als ein allgemeiner Begriff oder als eine 'Natur' aufzufassen wären." [Of individuals there is no natural science, because nothing more particular can be subsumed under them, in comparison with which they could still be conceived as a general concept or as a "nature."] H. Rickert, *Die Grenzen der naturwissenschaftlichen Begriffsbildung. Eine logische*

Against this conception I set the assertion that in nature as well as in the world of mind, general concepts and laws are in the last resort merely means for understanding the individual and historical (*das Einmalige*). It is the pride of science that it can form concepts and laws that hold for countless individuals and events. The capacity for this was already, for Plato, the typical figure of Greek science, a divine gift that ever anew filled his soul with admiration. Indeed, for Plato even the gods were subordinate to the eternal ideas and rejoiced to look up to them. But no actually given phenomenon, neither in nature nor in the world of mind, is exhaustively explained by being regarded as an example of a general concept or of a general law. To understand natural phenomena an interplay of laws is required. The laws are the instruments of thought that, through their co-operation, make the arising and development of a phenomenon intelligible. The solar system, the Earth, the organism, the personality, society—these are examples of individual totalities, whose history it is the task of science to write by means of the concepts and laws it is able to find. The history of science shows us clearly the increasing significance of the concept of development. In the end we are confronted with the task of writing the biography of ‘the World’—in so far as ‘the World’ can take shape as a rounded whole.

It is by no means the case that it is only history which exhibits the singular phenomenon (*das Einmalige*). Neither does absolute repetition occur in nature. No event ever recurs in exactly the same way. The immutability of nature is only apparent. It is a great world-drama (or perhaps rather an epic) that natural science and history together are to interpret. In it no scene, no situation, no line occurs more than once, if one carefully notes all the particulars, all the nuances and accents.

It is a great and lofty ideal that is hereby set before science. But it is necessary for rightly understanding the significance of science. Natural science approaches it by means of the great hypotheses that are raised on the basis of the laws that have been found. The laws always hold for simple and elementary relations; then it becomes a problem how these relations assert themselves within the wholes of various kinds and various degrees that experience shows. Whereas natural science goes from the elements to the totalities, the science of mind stands more directly before totalities

(events, personalities, societies), and such as do not allow themselves to be resolved into elements as easily as the material totalities that natural science treats. This, however, conditions only a difference of degree, not a difference of kind.

It is a long-familiar matter that the more comprehensive our concepts are, the poorer they are in content, and conversely. But it is not the richness of content that is to be subordinated to the comprehensive abstractions; it is these that are to be applied in order to understand and appreciate the former. The most universally valid sciences, logic and mathematics, are applied (apart from their own independent interest) as means and presuppositions for the more special sciences. The difficulties increase and the riddles become more numerous the more we approach the individual totalities. But these still indicate the ultimate objects and tasks of research.

When it is said that we cannot form proper concepts of the individual (*das Einmalige*), because there is nothing that can be subsumed under it, the answer must be that to the concept we form of an individual phenomenon, an event (e.g., the French Revolution) or a historical personality (e.g., Luther), belong all the various sides, properties, situations, and degrees of development that can contribute to its complete characterization. The “historical” concepts too, not merely the natural-scientific ones, comprise a manifold. Two kinds of individual concept must be distinguished. If I think of a historical personality in a definite situation (e.g., Luther at Worms), I can form of him a concrete individual concept; it acquires an intuitive character and bears the stamp of the memory-image or the fantasy-image. But no historical personality is exhausted in a single situation (any more than in a single property or a definite phase of development). My complete concept of it must correspond to all the situations in which it appears, and this may then be called a typical individual concept. The great difficulty with individual concepts is precisely to determine the relation between the concrete and the typical. Is it the young Luther, he who burned the papal bull, or is it the old Luther, the organizer and dogmatist, that is to be decisive for our final concept of Luther? Which of the phases of the French Revolution are to determine for us its (typical) concept?

The solution surely lies in this: that the typical concept of the individual indicates the law according to which the transition takes place from the one stage and the one

situation to the other. It is the law of change that gives expression to the essence of an individuality. If this law can be discovered, the nature of the individual must be rediscoverable in each of its stages, and one must be able to trace in the preceding stage the one that follows.⁴ Every psychological and historical presentation works to find such a law. Every good biography at least lets us divine it.

Art can show us only the concrete picture of individual situations and actions in which the personality appears, not the whole series of pictures that would be necessary to form a typical concept. Therefore contradictory interpretations of artistically presented figures can arise, e.g., of Hamlet. And yet art is able to carry through the individualization better than nature and history as a rule do.

However difficult it may be to form typical individual concepts, these nevertheless stand in the end as the highest task of thought. In order to be able to find general laws, science must often disregard the fact that everything experience shows us has an individual character, appears as a whole, even if perhaps a simple and elementary one. There are many degrees of individuality—from a cloud in the sky or a heap of sand on the shore to a human personality or a human society. All too often one meets the notion that nature “begins” with a chaos of elements and forces without quality and definite direction, and that all totalities and individualities are products of these. In our textbooks we begin with the simple and then pass to the composite, because understanding is most easily attained in that way. But what we know about the elements, about the simple, is in science always won through analysis of the total connection, by abstraction from individual phenomena that can vary to infinity.⁵

The consideration here set forth acquires special significance when the personality becomes an object of science. For the personality is not merely the example, nearest to us, of an individual totality. It is at the same time the most pronounced example of such, in that it displays the most intimate co-operation between elements and forces

⁴Leibniz, the real founder of the individual concept, already expressed this thought. It is “la loi de l’ordre” [the law of order], “la loi du changement” [the law of change], that constitutes the individuality of each being. *Lettre à Basnage de Beauval*, 1698 (G.W. Leibniz, *Opera philosophica*, ed. J.E. Erdmann, Berlin: Eichler, 1840, p. 151).

⁵Cf., with respect to the question treated in this section, my treatment of “Totality and Development” as special categories in *Den menneskelige Tanke*, Copenhagen: Gyldendalske Boghandel, Nordisk Forlag, 1910, pp. 218–37.

that lies within our experience.

We now turn to psychology, the empirical science of the personality, in order to see what it can teach us about the essence of the personality in itself.

III. The Principle of Personality in Psychology

In all empirical sciences the decisive definitions come at the end, not at the beginning. Psychology slowly works its way toward a concept of personality. All its various methods—observation, description, comparison, experiment—lead directly or indirectly to this goal. When we already now wish to attempt to set up—and in what precedes have presupposed—a concept of personality, this can be done only by way of hypothesis.

As a characteristic trait of personal beings must first be brought forward the uniformity in all states and undertakings. We call a human being a personality in all the more pronounced a degree, the more its thought, feelings, and endeavors are directed toward one goal—the more concentration there is in its spiritual life, the greater the continuity there is in its striving. Despite all changes and changing situations, there must appear in it a common law, a stamp of unity, or at least a coherence. This shows itself in the most exalted manner when the human being is subjected to great fluctuations, finds itself in strong conflicts, and yet, even in the dark hours, does not deny what, at the high points of life, stood before it as true and right.

The personality is maintained—like all life of the soul—only by an uninterrupted spiritual work, in which the psychic energy shows itself. It is a constant struggle to hold together and harmonize a given manifold of sensations, thoughts, feelings, drives, and interests, which go in different directions or are indifferent to one another. The greater this manifold and disparity, the more spiritual work is required for the life of the soul to subsist. And the more intimate the coherence and concentration, the greater the psychic energy that must be applied to this work.

It was this concept that I took as my basis when, about thirty years ago, I worked out my exposition of psychology. It had developed in me through criticism of the older English psychology (the so-called association psychology), which sought to explain

the life of the soul—and thereby the personality—as the product of a mechanical joining-together of psychic elements (independent sensations, representations, and so on), which stood in roughly the same relation to the personality as a heap of stones to the house that is built. The task now became to show that there is never, so long as the life of the soul subsists, a complete lack of coherence and unity in it, although this coherence can assume very elementary forms. I supported myself here especially on the doctrine of mental illnesses, which proves that mental illness consists specifically in a dissolution of the coherence within the life of the soul, in a weakening of the psychic energy. Later my conception was confirmed by Pierre Janet's work, especially by his description of "psychasthenia," a spiritual weakness characterized by the fact that no psychic content, no psychic elements, have fallen away, but that there is a lack of energy for cohesion and concentration, on account of which patients suffering from this illness are unable to make decisions, to take resolutions. There is lacking what Janet aptly calls "psychic tension" (*tension psychologique*), which corresponds to what I call synthesis or psychic energy.

In the child the psychic energy is not yet so developed that a strong and lasting concentration can become possible. Spiritual development consists not merely in a manifold content's being taken up through experience and tradition, but first and foremost in the energy that brings about an inner coherence. The dream-state is characterized especially by the lack of firm coherence and consistency in the content of consciousness. Like the child's consciousness, it has a sporadic character. In it one representation easily passes over into another; the situations change without this, as a rule, arousing astonishment and without an explanation of this alternation being sought. In the waking consciousness definite directions are held fast and pursued, and the changes are motivated, or, if motivation seems to be lacking, become riddles. Even if there is here only a difference of degree—since there are also waking dreams—this difference nevertheless clearly shows the significance of the psychic energy, especially when we have reason to assume that the dream-consciousness denotes a state between the conscious and the unconscious.

It is, however, not merely from weakness or lack of development that the individual elements of the life of the soul—sensations, thoughts, feelings, and so on—can appear

independently and without closer coherence. We can also, by attention and analysis, bring forward and isolate individual elements and, as far as possible, consider them each by itself. We must distinguish in order to be able to apprehend distinctly. But such distinctions are more or less artificial. They are reflections, the work of after-thought, and must not be confused with what immediate experience offers. The more we are able to immerse ourselves in our purely immediate and involuntary experiences, the more clearly will our life of the soul show itself to flow as a continuous stream, in which no element can be isolated from the others without changing its character. This continuous character of the immediate psychic experiences has in the most recent time been demonstrated in a brilliant and emphatic manner by William James and Henri Bergson.

Finally, experimental psychology too points in the same direction. Its real founder, Fechner, proved that the individual sense-sensations do not arise independently of one another, but are interwoven with one another, in that after a very strong stimulation of the sense-organs a stronger stimulation than usual is required for a sense-sensation of a certain strength to arise. The so-called contrast-effects too bear witness to the great coherence, even in our elementary life of the soul. The green color appears more pronounced (more saturated) after the red, which is its complementary color, than after other colors. The absolute independence of the sensations is merely apparent.

And if we consider the matter from the physiological side, we are led in the same direction. However the relation between soul and body may be, it nevertheless stands fast that the life of the soul is exceedingly intimately bound to the nervous system. But the significance of the latter lies in this: that it is a great organ of concentration, through which all parts of the body stand in close connection and reciprocal action, so that thereby a unified and concentrated performance of the organism as a whole is possible. And the higher and the more energetically developed a life of the soul we have reason to assume in a living being, the greater the role the nervous system plays, and the more centralized it is. In the outer, sensible appearance too the distinctive character of the life of the soul, and thereby of the personality, manifests itself.

It is only in those beings whose life of the soul has attained a higher degree of unity and clarity that we speak of personality. Personal life can appear in inconceivably

many different degrees; for a large part the difference between the various individuals rests on such a difference of degree in the intensity of concentration. Only in human beings does one speak of personality. The life of the soul of animals must, to judge by all experience, be assumed to be partly so simple, partly so changing and incoherent, that we must picture it most nearly in analogy with our dream-life.

In what precedes we have defined the concept of personality solely from its formal side. We have spoken of energy and concentration, of unity and coherence. But the content too, which is gathered into unity, has its significance. Two personal beings with the same capacity for concentration can nevertheless be very different on account of the different content they contain, and around which they gather themselves, as well as the different direction in which their energy is released.

In the real respect, the personality acquires its stamp from the fact that it embraces a central content, a ruling interest and striving, which conditions the direction in which the concentration takes place and the psychic energy is applied. Each individual experience, thought, mood, decision acquires within the personality its definite place by its relation to a fundamental value that constitutes the real distinctive mark of an individual personality, just as the degree of the energy of concentration constitutes its formal distinctive mark. The little world that each personality embraces has at every time and at every stage of development a center, in relation to which all other elements in the personal life are determined with respect to value and significance. To know oneself is to have consciousness of this central interest, this fundamental value, which constitutes what one might call the real I. If there were no such constantly active elements in us, we would be strangers to ourselves. There can be constant elements of a purely peripheral kind in us; but the deeper self-knowledge presupposes central elements, and it therefore makes a comical impression when Holberg's Jeppe recognizes himself by his hollow tooth. Such a peripheral element cannot determine the place of all other elements in the inner world-order.⁶

In personal life a crisis arises if the central elements are changed. This can happen through sudden catastrophes or through long periods of doubt and unrest; but it can

⁶On the difference between the formal and the real I, cf. my *Psykologi i Omrids paa Grundlag af Erfaringen* [Outlines of Psychology on the Basis of Experience], Copenhagen: Philipsen, 1882 (and later), V B, 5.

also happen slowly and imperceptibly, so that only afterward do we discover that an essential change has taken place with us and in us. Something can work its way forward in us that quite involuntarily determines our striving, but of which we become conscious only later. An example that lies near at hand here is Geijer's relation to the thought to which he gave the name the principle of personality. It arose in him at a late point in his life, in his fifty-fifth year, but he then discovered that he had long followed it without himself knowing it. In a letter that he wrote on his last birthday (1847), he expresses himself about it in the following manner:

There is a fundamental thought in my whole life, which steps forth ever more clearly, and which is not my own work; for it has led me and carried me right up to this day. Were I to give it a name, it is none other than the much-disputed principle of personality, whose prophet I have become almost against my will. I mean by this that I have held off from myself and shaken off everything that could hinder and hamper the development of my own innermost being. This has for the most part happened without my own co-operation. But it has now come over me, and it becomes clear to me that what I have fought for in literature, in politics, and in religion is properly this my innermost personality and its right, in the best sense.⁷

Thus the very developmental history of the principle of personality presents an example of a chief point in the nature and conditions of personal life. We are led to see that the personality cannot be said to be exhaustively determined by what, at a given moment, appears with clear consciousness and full understanding. Just as one assumes that in organic life apparently sudden changes (mutations) can occur, through which new types can arise, so too in the spiritual domain, through a quiet increase, changes in the lines of development can be prepared which to the outer observer may seem inexplicable, although they have their cause in what has taken place in the innermost core of the life of the soul. We have here a real example of the difference between concrete and typical individual representations that was set forth in the preceding section. The typical concept of a personality can be reached only by

⁷E.G. Geijer, *Samlade Skrifter*, sec. I, vol. 1, Stockholm: P.A. Norstedt & Söner, 1849, p. XXXVIII.

following it through its various stages of development. And it is often the later stages that draw attention to the content and significance of the earlier ones. Descriptive psychology has here a great field before it. And it must be hoped that here, when the sense for personal life—its forms and phases—has been developed still more than hitherto, a significant work will be able to be carried out. Hitherto, dogmatic and doctrinaire conceptions of various kinds have hindered an uninterrupted work in this direction. Descriptive psychology approaches the boundary between science and art; but by clarity in conception and by the application of the comparative method it can conquer new terrain for science.

IV. The Principle of Personality in Ethics

From the intellectual significance of the principle of personality I now pass to its practical significance, which is the original one.

Every principle sets up a demand to our thought or to our will. The principle of personality makes demands in both directions. I have attempted to show what demands it makes on the life of thought. The practical demand that it makes becomes, as I shall now attempt to show, of great significance for ethics and the philosophy of religion.

In Kant and Geijer, in Kierkegaard and Sibbern alike, the principle of personality is set up in a critical and polemical direction against the dominion of society and tradition over the individual personalities. It demands their free and independent development. But it nevertheless contains within itself the possibility of letting both the social and the individualistic conception of human life and human action come into their right.

From a purely social point of view it is emphasized that the individual always arises within a society. An isolated individual does not exist. The individual conscience itself, the innermost in the human being, is a product of social life, a social inheritance. The individual virtues are socially conditioned. And on the other hand the individual, with its longing and its striving, is vanishing in comparison with the life of society, which continues through countless generations. It is merely a drop in the ocean. Its

happiness, its knowledge, its conscience acquire vanishingly slight significance in contrast to the great and constant course of development of the race and of society. And the only measure of the individual's significance lies in the contribution it is able to make to this course of development.

The individualist answers, for his part: Where should the significance of society be sought if not in the security and support it gives to the development of the individual personalities? The worth of a society is measured by the degree to which it fulfills this task. This is the only possible measure, already for the good reason that society consists of individuals and exists only in and through them.

If the social conception makes the individual a means for society, then the individualistic conception makes society a means for the individual.

This opposition does not come forward so long as life is essentially lived under the involuntary guidance of instinct and tradition. But every cultural development comes to a point where the individual no longer feels itself in solidarity with society, but where society and its demands stand as mere tradition, mere authority, perhaps as purely external power. It is such an age that, in Geijer's words, suffers from its own thoughts. There have then—precisely as a consequence of social development—developed independent personalities; but society does not yet fully dare to acknowledge their independence, and they cannot acknowledge the worth of society. It is really only in such times that philosophy arises. Philosophy therefore acquires, in its origin, an individualistic character. Greek philosophy, the thought of the Renaissance, and the philosophy of the eighteenth century are significant examples of this. The philosophy of the nineteenth century denotes—both in its romantic and in its positivistic main form—a reaction against this, just as the great labor associations too, whose coming into being belongs among this century's greatest events, have an anti-individualistic character. But the problem arises again and again, and we have entered the new century with it.

With respect to this problem a sharp distinction must be made between the historical and the philosophical mode of consideration. It is a fact that the individual is developed within society. Its very longing and its striving, its ethical conceptions and the criticism it exercises toward tradition, cannot be understood if one starts merely

from the individual, thought of as isolated. The individual is to that extent a product of social causes. And society extends far beyond the individual, both into the future and into the past. But does there follow from this, with necessity, an obligation for the individual to bow under society's laws and to work for its welfare? The individual can, after all, regard the social development, whose fruit it itself is, as a mere fact, a result, which it—if it has the spiritual and mental power to do so—now applies in the service of its own individual ends. It serves no purpose to speak of a social debt that the individual is to pay off by working for society's continued development, for the question is precisely why the individual should acknowledge this debt. Why should the individual not regard itself as sovereign?

What individualism in its extreme forms asserts is really this: that the personality is to be an end without being a means. Against the principle of personality, by contrast, it does not conflict that the personality is a means—that it serves a cause, an idea, serves society—provided only that this serving is a means to a higher development of the individual itself. The human being grows, as Schiller has said, with his greater ends. But these greater ends it can find only in social life. Just as thought grows only by seeking truth—that is, by finding as great a connection as possible among as many experiences as possible—so the life of feeling and will grows only through the experiences that are made and the work that is performed by participation in the life of society and of the race. But the condition for this is that society's forms and demands be modified, so that the social work—the paying off of “the social debt”—can serve to bring to development powers and possibilities that would otherwise slumber unused in the individual. The personality can make itself a means for society only when society also makes itself a means for the personality. The possibility of this is the kernel of the so-called social question. In all of history we find great groups of human beings who have essentially been treated as means, without society's regarding itself as having duties toward them. All justified social reforms aim at abolishing this dualism of end and means. Society must, if it is to continue to subsist, acknowledge the principle of personality, even though this was originally enunciated from individualistic standpoints.

Some forms of individualism, however, overlook this view. Max Stirner proclaimed

(in his book *Der Einzige und sein Eigentum*, 1845) a philosophy of the I as abstract as it was absolute, according to which there is, neither within nor outside us, anything whose claim we are to acknowledge. So long as you believe in the truth, he even says, you do not believe in yourself alone and are only a servant. Every right is a privilege. I acknowledge no right, and I do not care to have right, if only I have might!—Here society is not merely made into a means; it disappears entirely. In contrast to this, an individualism or “anarchism” such as Kropotkin’s rests on the experience of the significance that involuntary association has for all living beings, and he has depicted it in an interesting manner in his book *Mutual Aid* (1902). Kropotkin merely opposes centralization, the state’s intervention in the spontaneous social formations in smaller circles. In neighborly relations life orders itself as if of its own accord. What Kropotkin does not have in view is that these involuntary associations—like the earlier guilds and fellowships—can lead to stagnation in oppression and injustice, and that therefore an intervention can be needful. But he is right in this, that the state ought not to intervene unnecessarily in the smaller circles in which life stirs of its own accord—for the same reason that society ought not to intervene in the free development of the individual personality, unless this becomes necessary out of regard for the free development of other personalities. It is in the interior of the individual that the new powers which can carry social life forward have their origin. The growth of the future sprouts there. It is thus for its own sake that society ought to acknowledge the principle of personality. Its real power shows itself in the strength and independence with which the individuals can live within its frame.

One often meets, among modern sociologists, a certain mystical conception of the concept of society, in that they assume a social origin for ideas and feelings. If by this is merely meant that ideas and feelings are developed in the individual through reciprocal action with others, it is completely correct. But when “society” is invoked as a cause, it is mysticism. Society as such can produce right, morality, and religion as little as it can produce poetry and science. The “folk-songs” were not composed by “the folk,” but by individual singers whose names are forgotten because their work at once became everyone’s property and, by passing through many hands, underwent changes that often made it into something other than it originally was. At earlier

stages of culture individual initiative is easily forgotten. And it is precisely such stages of culture that the sociologists prefer to occupy themselves with. At later stages the founding personalities play a greater role and are not so easily forgotten. An appeal to “society” as the explanation of a phenomenon is in reality an *asylum ignorantiae*.⁸

With this, the justification of setting society and individual in opposition to one another is not to be denied. The concept of society contains the fact that, by means of the life and work of changing generations, a capital is gathered, a potential energy, which is deposited in institutions and traditions, indeed in language itself. Here is something that points beyond the individual—back into the past and out toward the future—something that belongs to no single individual whatever. They are values that are bound, and that can be released only through the work of individuals. A social order is valued not merely according to the capital it thus has at its disposal, but also according to the manner in which it is able to release it. There can be dead values that acquire the semblance of life through social institutions. Whether the values are living or dead can be decided only by whether or not they benefit the development of free personalities. For the free personalities are both the centers in which the values of life reveal themselves and the centers from which the work of finding and producing values proceeds.

According to this whole view, society and individual stand at the same time as end and means for one another.

The highest ethical thought is this: that the individual personality is to develop in such a way that precisely by its independent and distinctive development it, in the best manner, directly or indirectly, helps others to develop independently and distinctively. Herein consists the true justice, which Westermarck rightly calls “the flower of all moral feelings.”⁹ It harmoniously unites self-assertion and devotion, the interest of

⁸It is in this connection of interest that E.G. Geijer’s defection from “the historical school,” which was the romantic precursor of modern sociology, was precisely brought about by his historical studies (E.G. Geijer, *Samlade skrifter*, sec. I, vol. 8, Stockholm: P.A. Norstedt & Söner, 1855, p. 520). That is to say, he recognized that it was not an explanation of a phenomenon to appeal to “society” or “history” *en bloc*. And he recognized “that history cannot give, but can indeed modify, the principle of action, and that the latter must, on the contrary, be the contribution of each age itself.”

⁹“Justice, the flower of all moral feelings.” E. Westermarck, *The Origin and Development of the Moral Ideas*, 2 vols., London & New York: Macmillan, 1906–08, vol. 1, p. 124. Cf. my *Etik. En Fremstilling af de etiske Principer og deres Anvendelse paa de vigtigste Livsforhold*, Copenhagen: P.G. Philipsen, 1887 (and

the individual and of society. By it society lives in the individuals, not merely outside and above them. In it the principle of personality comes into its full right.

V. Can the Principle of Personality Be Proved and Carried Through?

The question can no longer be postponed, whether the principle of personality, with which we have here occupied ourselves, can be shown to be valid. In the immediately preceding lecture a justification was indeed given, but the question is whether this justification does not itself rest on certain presuppositions. It consisted in this: that the said principle made possible the most harmonious development of society and the most intimate reciprocal action between individuals.¹⁰ But this train of thought is naturally taken as valid only by those for whom such a development of the human race stands as a good. It follows from the thought of universal human welfare. But the question is how matters stand with this thought itself. The answer to this question becomes decisive for the position of ethics as a science.

Value can be measured only by value. And value points back to a feeling—and about feelings, it is said, there can be no dispute. Yet one can, when a certain value is known and acknowledged, infer from it what place other values consistently occupy in relation to the given value. In every human being—and on the whole in every people and in every age—a certain fundamental value asserts itself, an interest that lies deepest and exercises the strongest influence. It corresponds to, or rather belongs to, what I call the real side of the personality. And it decides what else acquires value,

later), III,9; IX,1; X,4.

¹⁰I first gave this demonstration in my *Etik. En Fremstilling af de etiske Principer og deres Anvendelse paa de vigtigste Livsforhold*, Copenhagen: P.G. Philipsen, 1887 (and later), VIII,6, cf. XIII,6, where I also criticized Kant's artificial argumentation. Geijer's demonstration (*Samlade skrifter*, sec. I, vol. 5, Stockholm: P.A. Norstedt & Söner, 1852, pp. 132–37) rests chiefly on the fact that the human being discovers in every other human being a being of the same worth as itself, as well as on the fact that the human being can develop into a personality only in reciprocal action with other human beings. But this does not, after all, exclude that the human being can make these kindred beings, whose co-operation it cannot do without, into mere means for itself! — Karl Marx (*Das Kapital. Kritik der politischen Oekonomie*, vol. 1: *Der Produktionsprocess des Kapitals*, Hamburg: Otto Meisner, 1867, p. 646) and Léon Bourgeois (in *La Philosophie de la solidarité*, Paris: Colin, 1902, p. 38) set up the proposition as self-evident, which a glance at history easily shows to be incorrect.

and what value it acquires. He for whom his own advantage is the fundamental value cannot, without inconsistency, sacrifice himself for other persons or for general ends. Conversely, he in whom love of humanity determines the fundamental value cannot consistently act egoistically. Our ethical judgments are determined by our fundamental values, and these in turn by our ruling feelings.

But can one then assert that all human beings, at all times and under all circumstances, have the same fundamental values? That would surely be an unpsychological and unhistorical assertion, notwithstanding that thinkers like Kant and Bentham have, each in his own way, maintained it. The fundamental values arise through psychological and historical processes that are never present as wholly completed. A fundamental value can never be set up as self-evident. It must grow forth, and it depends in each individual case how far the growth has advanced. It is of no help to say that the human being grows with his greater ends, for the human being must have grown in order to be able to set himself greater ends, and must then have grown further by working at them. It is of no use, as Goethe has said, to speak to the larva that crawls in the dust about how it shall one day fly from flower to flower.

The principle of personality as a general ethical principle presupposes the development of a consciousness of humanity, a general love of humankind, such as appeared in the last centuries before Christ through a peculiar fusion of Platonic and Stoic ideas. Later it has had a long and changing history. It has had to struggle, not merely with the egoism of individuals, but also with the egoism of families, classes, nations, and confessions. In the eighteenth century it broke fully through and made its definite demands on bourgeois society. But it is constantly a church militant. Therefore the consequences that are drawn from the general consciousness of humanity cannot become valid for all either.

Our thought is able to do nothing other than draw the consequence of certain definite presuppositions. It is the affair of experience to decide whether these presuppositions are found everywhere and in everyone. This does not diminish the significance of thought, nor of ethical thinking. Thought can only bring to clear consciousness what lies in our presuppositions. And the significance of philosophical ethics rests precisely on this too. It is to set forth the consequences that can rightly

be drawn from a certain stage of the development of human feeling. Later it can be investigated how far the consequence of other stages of development coincides with them, and what difference unequal motivations and unequal presuppositions bring about.¹¹

Where the ethical motivation stands at its limit, because its presuppositions are no longer acknowledged, there arises the question of how these presuppositions can be realized. This becomes the affair of moral pedagogy. It is through education that the fundamental values are formed. The word education is taken here in the widest sense, so that the whole history of mankind is seen as one great education. It is the affair of psychology and sociology to show how this education proceeds involuntarily and unconsciously in individuals and in generations, and what means stand at our disposal when we will, fully consciously, to educate human beings.

Schopenhauer has said that it is hard to ground morality, but easy to preach morality. In the first part of his sentence he is right. But he is wrong in saying that it should be easy to preach morality, if by this is meant leading human beings to such a development of their personality that they can, by their own power and desire, find the right. Neither under education may a personal being be regarded and treated merely as a means—not even as a means to its own future. The larva ought to be treated as a larva, right up until it becomes a butterfly. It is the great thought in Rousseau's pedagogy that the child is to be treated as a child and not merely as a becoming adult. It is thus a matter of taking the one who is to be educated at the standpoint at which he stands, and then, along the paths of self-development and self-activity, leading him to the level, the fundamental value, that can form the starting point for the inferences one wishes him to draw. Here Spinoza's words hold, that there is no way in which one can better show one's spiritual power and capacity than by leading others to live according to their own clear conviction.

If difficulties are thus bound up with the proof of ethical principles, there are also difficulties in their being carried through in each individual case. Even if the

¹¹I developed this conception of the scientific limitation and significance of ethics long ago in my *Etik. En Fremstilling af de etiske Principer og deres Anvendelse paa de vigtigste Livsforhold*, Copenhagen: P.G. Philipsen, 1887 (and later), chapter III. It is a pleasure to me to meet a similar thought in E. Westermarck's *The Origin and Development of the Moral Ideas*, vol. 1, London & New York: Macmillan, 1906, pp. 17, 104 ff.

fundamental value is presupposed to be the same, the question nevertheless arises whether, proceeding from the common presuppositions, one can make the same ethical demands of all individuals. Individuals are different, both with respect to the kind of their abilities and with respect to the degree of psychic energy they have at their disposal. From this it follows that one cannot demand the same of all. Neither what is to be demanded, nor how much is to be demanded, can be established once and for all, but must be determined with respect to the nature and powers of the individuals. The same burden weighs differently on different shoulders. There are human beings who are forced to fight a hard battle to fulfill the most elementary demands with respect to self-control, which others fulfill completely involuntarily. The ethical work can be the same, although the results become of highly different value. Human beings are like runners who begin the race from very different starting points. For one cannot deny that in the ethical respect, as in other respects, human beings are very differently equipped from the beginning.

It would conflict with the principle of personality to judge the individual by an abstract rule that takes no account of his individual conditions. The task becomes to individualize the ethical demands, so that each one comes to perform the work that accords with his personal conditions, and is thereby led onto a track that can lead further. Ethics is still far from such an individualization, and this also requires, after all, great psychological and great practical knowledge of human beings, as well as great patience. It is easier to systematize and to enunciate universally valid propositions than to find the individual starting points in the particular cases. System and variation stand, in ethics as in biology, in sharp opposition to one another.

In concepts such as equity and pardon, however, individualization has long since been acknowledged. Aristotle already set up the concept of equity as a peculiar form of justice, necessitated by the fact that there are individual nuances that prevent the application of a general law. And that pardon is applied can, juridically, be motivated only by the fact that legislation is not in a position to take account of all individual circumstances. Pardon is, as Ihering says, justice's self-correction.

It is, however, not merely downward that individualization is demanded, but also upward. There are not merely individuals who begin their ethical development from

a lower level than the average; there are also individuals who from the beginning are equipped with special conditions for ethical work. And by virtue of the principle of personality the ethical law must make greater demands on them than on others. They must themselves demand more of themselves than is demanded of others. They debase themselves by being content with a minimum. It is their “duty” to acquire “merit.” Schiller’s Wilhelm Tell recognizes this when he answers his wife’s complaint—that his countrymen always turn to him when something great is at stake—with the words: “Ein Jeder wird besteuert nach Vermögen!” [Each is taxed according to his means!]

In the pedagogical respect the distinction between “duty” and “merit,” on which Catholic theology lays such great weight, can be of significance. Partly it can be hard enough to get all to fulfill the minimal demands that one often thinks of with the word “duty”; partly it can be needful to warn against ethical foolhardiness, against venturing further than one’s powers allow. The difficulty lies in this: that only by attempting, by venturing, can we come to know the extent of our powers. By holding ourselves back we can cause powers and possibilities in us, which could have been developed through work for greater ends, to remain unused. Perhaps the attempt to perform a great action leads to our coming to know our limitation. Perhaps it leads directly to a tragic result. But such, after all, are the conditions of life. As Longfellow has said: “Only those who brave its dangers comprehend its mystery.”

VI. The Principle of Personality and the View of Life

There still remains to be investigated the significance of the principle of personality for the view of life and for faith—that is, its religious significance, when one takes the word “religious” in the wider sense. I believe that this significance is in constant growth, and that the most essential side of the position of the religious problem in our days rests upon it.

There are three elements that at any given time determine human beings’ faith: science, tradition, and personal experience. They play a very different role in different individuals, and even where they all assert themselves strongly, they are combined with one another in very different ways, whereby the view of life acquires a different

timbre. There are scarcely two human beings in whom they appear in the same manner or are connected in the same way. It would be an interesting study to penetrate into these inequalities. Unfortunately such a study is possible only in an imperfect degree with respect to contemporaries.

More and more the first two elements, science and tradition, lead over to the third, a personal experience of the course and the conditions of life.

(a) The newer science, whose origin is to be sought in the century of the Renaissance, has exercised great influence on the view of life, especially through two principal thoughts. The one is the conception of the unsurveyability of the universe, of the unbounded extension of space and time. The bounded stage on which the human being had hitherto been able to picture the epic of existence spread out now appeared as a vanishing point. The other is the conception of a great law-boundness in the whole of nature, a law-boundness that is proved step by step by the fact that every change in the world of nature or of mind is explained by its definite connection with other changes, without causes that lie outside a possible experience being invoked. This scientific concept of cause is first applied to the inorganic domain, later also to the organic domain, as well as to the spiritual domain.

The impressions that this great change in the conception of the world made on human beings' view of life were very different. In some it awakened enthusiasm, in that existence now, more than before, acquired the stamp of the sublime, at the same time as the conviction was clarified that it is, after all, the same forces that work in the nature of the human being and in the infinite universe. In spirits such as Bruno, Böhme, and Spinoza this direction in the view of life asserts itself. In others this expansion of the horizon, which transformed the earthly stage into a vanishing point, awakened anxiety and dread, and led to an all the more passionate clinging to the old faith. Pascal is the great example of this direction. There were, finally, those who laid no weight at all on the great change in the world-picture, who did not become clear about its fundamental significance, whether in their view of life they held to the traditional faith or went their own ways. — Even to this day one finds these three standpoints with respect to the great problem.

One need not exaggerate the significance of science to be sure that it will come

to exercise an increasing influence on the views of life. One will not be able to go around science. Pascal already said, after all, that if the Earth really rotates, then it rotates with both believers and unbelievers. Science will work most through the quiet power that lies in its method, its way of asking and of answering. Less and less will human beings who are educated with this method be able to take mystical and anthropomorphic explanations as real answers to the riddles of experience. It is less the special results of science than the way of thinking that it teaches human beings that will come to determine the future of the views of life. In the first section of this presentation I sought, moreover, to emphasize that it is no alien power that here comes to meet the personality. The scientific interest and the scientific capacity are closely connected with the essence of the personality and bear its stamp. The deep longing for wholeness, which is the innermost in the personality, also lies at the basis of science. Science is the work of the personality, which it cannot disown. And it is of no help to close one's eyes to the expanded horizon that science opens. We must see ourselves and the stage for all our work and all our interests as smaller circles within the great circle whose center is everywhere and whose circumference is nowhere.

Meanwhile it will scarcely ever become possible, from the standpoints and results of science, to construct views of life for the various individual personalities. As we have seen (at the end of the second and third sections), it is indeed the last and highest task of science to understand and explain individual totalities, and therefore personalities too; but here there can be only approximate assumptions, and science here approaches art. For the individual, the purely individual experiences of life will always be the essential thing for the rounding-off that he involuntarily makes when the view of life is formed. A human being is more than an example of a general law, and even the human life that moves in the narrowest circle can give its contribution to mankind's great common experience. At any rate, only the individual can know how the course of life and fate is at the particular place in existence where his existence finds itself. "The humblest defends its place in life's garland," a Danish poet has said.

(b) In whatever manner the religious traditions may have arisen, their continued subsistence and the significance they still have for so many rest on the circumstance that in dogma and cult the deepest experiences of life of countless generations are

deposited. The history of religion shows us how conceptions that were earlier religiously indifferent have, under the influence of great movements within the life of feeling, been taken into the service of religion. Thus it has gone, for example, with the idea of the transmigration of souls in India and with the thoughts of Greek philosophy in the dogmatics of the Christian church. But within the religions they are regarded not merely as symbols of experiences of life. They are fixed as dogmas that are to contain the solution to the riddle of life. They are torn up from the living soil in which they have grown. Yet more and more, in the religious consciousness of our time, a conflict asserts itself between the symbolic-poetic and the literal-dogmatic conception. It comes ever more clearly forward that the riddles which science cannot solve are not solved by the religious conceptions either, already for the reason that science both asks and answers differently than religion does. The time is past when religion could satisfy all sides of the human life of the soul. Intellectually it has lost the battle, however matters may stand with the other sides of the life of the soul. In our days much noble energy is wasted, in the most independent spirits, on the work that the conflict between religion and science calls forth—an energy that could have been applied to founding a view of life grounded on one's own experience.

And yet it is not the relation between science and religion that is the most important thing in the position of the religious problem in our days. From both sides what can be said has been said, and continued discussion will bring nothing new. The decisive point lies, by contrast, in the relation between religion and personality. In opposition to the immutability of the religious tradition stands the free, the personal experience of life, whose richness and fullness grow as the distinctive character and independent justification of the individual personalities are acknowledged. Every human individual is one of the centers where the value of life is described, and one of the starting points from which new values can be found or produced. It is not so much before the tribunal of science as before that of life that religion is to be placed in the future. This happens by virtue of the principle of personality. For just as little is it to be a mere means for the preservation of a religious tradition.¹²

¹²Since I have in the foregoing often referred to Erik Gustaf Geijer as one of the most important representatives of the principle of personality, I shall adduce a statement showing that he remained true to his principle in his religious conception too. "I am," he writes in a letter, "neither a church-Christian

The religious need is a need to hold fast the values of life beyond the limits within which the human will can work for them. Could the human being himself completely secure his spiritual and material property absolutely, religion would not arise in any form. But now there comes hope or fear, exaltation or dejection, according as one feels oneself at the high point of life or in its depths. The cults of the great religions give, in the most exalted poetry, expression to these opposite moods that the epic of life brings with it, and which will always assert themselves in everyone who lives life wholly and fully, and whose sympathy is not blunted and limited.

I will not prophesy about the religion of the future. I am a philosopher, not a prophet. But everything speaks for it, that the more the real and constant experiences of life acquire influence on the religious life, the more the symbolic-poetic conception of the religious experiences will replace the literal-dogmatic one, and make it ever more conscious. And thereby a great step will have been taken toward a free, self-acquired human view of life. —

(c) Both science and tradition thus point to personal experience of life. A thoroughgoing individualization of the view of life is necessary. The personality is to set its stamp on its faith. Only thus does this faith become a testimony to how life moves at this particular place in the world. And when advanced psychological investigations lead us to recognize that the individual differences are far greater and deeper than hitherto assumed, the views of life of the future will probably exhibit greater oppositions than one can get a glimpse of so long as the common confessional dogmas cover the mutually divergent conceptions and applications of an identically worded confession.¹³ It is a gleam of light in the darkness of the time that this side of the

nor even a Bible-Christian ... [I] am a Christian on my own account. Thousands find themselves in the same position as I—in fact all who cannot content themselves with a mere authority-faith, and who are compelled to build their own religion out of their own experience and reflection. This individual element, now the only living thing in religion ... points everywhere, however, toward a common goal [...].” (*Samlade Skrifter*, sec. I, vol. 1, Stockholm: P.A. Norstedt & Söner, 1849, p. XXXII f.) (Emphasis mine.) Yet Geijer, who stood under the strong influence of the romantic speculation of his time, also gave his principle of personality a theological and metaphysical significance which is untenable, since every attempt in this direction leads to a play with analogies and allegories that can neither be carried through consistently nor confirmed by experience. Cf. on this my *Religionsfilosofi*, Copenhagen & Kristiania: Gyldendalske Boghandel, Nordisk Forlag, 1901 (and later), §32.

¹³Cf. the survey, of the individual differences that can acquire significance for the view of life, which I have sought to give in my *Religionsfilosofi*, Copenhagen & Kristiania: Gyldendalske Boghandel, Nordisk

principle of personality is more and more being acknowledged. If it is acknowledged completely, a wholly new conception of the deepest problems will assert itself. For the time being the old dogmas struggle with the new doubt. Through this purgatory the decisive victory is to be won for the principle of personality.

Forlag, 1901 (and later), §§36–43 and §§94–96. — We stand here at a point that has been strongly emphasized by Danish philosophers, all the way from Holberg to Sibbern and Kierkegaard. See on this my book *Danske Filosofer* [Danish Philosophers], Copenhagen: Gyldendalske Boghandel, Nordisk Forlag, 1909.